

Florian Wirtz

A

lot was expected of Florian Wirtz when he made his big-money move to English champion Liverpool last summer. But 11 months down the line, the story has not panned out as he would have

hoped.

A measly haul of five goals and three assists in 32 league appearances, with the possibility of missing out on Champions League football next season, has tarnished Wirtz's reputation as one of the most exciting youngsters in the world.

But scattered across those 11 months were eight appearances for Germany, during which he recorded three goals and four assists, proving that the 23-year-old is not entirely to blame for Liverpool.

Wirtz, who is hailed for his expertise in finding spaces on the pitch, was given a more rigid attacking role by Liverpool boss Arne Slot, leaving him vulnerable to the physicality of English football.

Meanwhile, in national colours, he is deployed by Julian Nagelsmann as a free-roaming midfielder partnered with Jamal Musiala. Despite starting in a wider position, he is allowed to drift into central areas more often instead of hugging the touchline.

As gaps naturally open up, his quick feet help him avoid physical battles with the opposition and pick out a pass or even have a crack at goal.

An ACL injury ruled Wirtz out of the competition in Qatar four years ago, and this time around, a hefty price tag has heightened the scrutiny around him. But with a wealth of experience under his belt, Wirtz will arrive at the quadrennial tournament knowing that a sparkling outing will be enough to silence the critics.

GERMANY

Age - 23

Club - Liverpool

NT Appearances - 39

Goals - 10

Assists - 11

